

running across Orange Plank Road, as A. P. Hill's Third Corps bore down on them. Thousands of men on both sides were soon clawing their way through briars and stumbling across ravines, trying to form orderly battle lines. Formations and directions of advance rapidly went astray in the tangled maze of undergrowth.

The confused fighting continued all day. At Grant's headquarters, the general ceaselessly whittled sticks and chain-smoked cigars as he waited for reports. In the woods, the volume of musketry was rapidly becoming a deafening cacophony as yelling men, groping blindly, shot point-blank at muzzle flashes in the gloom—"firing by earsight." Storms of bullets tore through the woods and cut men down in droves. Brush fires became runaway infernos, burning to death many of the helpless wounded, whose hideous screams could be heard above the din. Smoke had turned the sun a lurid bloodred long before twilight finally descended and the battle subsided. Weary survivors literally fell to sleep, rifles in hand.

Early on May 6, the fighting resumed as Grant went on the attack. The Union right wing kept up the pressure, then W. S. Hancock's Second Corps, at the Brock Road, smashed through the underbrush into A. P. Hill's ragged lines, which broke and fled.

Lee himself rode into the bedlam, trying desperately to rally his troops before all was lost. With only his staff and a single artillery battery standing between his army and disaster, Lee saw that Longstreet's divisions were finally arriving down the Plank Road. "Who are you, my boys?" Lee cried above the uproar. "Texas boys," came the reply. "Texans always move them!" the general shouted, waving his hat, and with a strange light in his eyes began to lead them into battle. Grimy hands tugged at his bridle, as men yelled, "Go back, General Lee! Lee to the rear!" Brigadier General John Gregg's 800 Texans surged forward and stopped the onslaught, although at a fearful price. Fewer than 250 of the men who charged emerged unscathed.

3,750 The approximate number of men in the two armies who were killed in action in the Battle of the Wilderness. Hundreds of others, recorded as "missing," probably died in the brush fires ignited by the fighting.